

Pregnancy



Chamomile
(*Chamomilla recutita*)

Although in many cultures herbs have traditionally been taken throughout pregnancy, it is wise to take herbs medicinally only when essential. Some herbs such as German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77), linden (*Tilia* spp., p. 277), and cornsilk (*Zea mays*, p. 154) are very useful and can be taken safely for 2–3 weeks at a time during pregnancy. Other herbs should be avoided altogether, as they have constituents that stimulate the muscles of the uterus and, in large doses, could cause a miscarriage. It is safe to continue using herbs in cooking throughout pregnancy.

! Seek immediate professional advice for:

- Prolonged nausea causing an inability to eat properly and frequent vomiting leading to dehydration
- Frequent urination lasting for more than 3 days (or with pain after 2 days)
- Breast pain with swollen glands under the arms or fever
- Fluid retention that has not reduced after 3 days

Maintaining Vitality

Pregnancy is a time of great change for the body. Many minor ailments can be relieved by homemade herbal remedies.

Morning sickness (sensations of nausea) need not be restricted to the morning. Generally starting in the 4th–6th week and lasting until the 14th–16th week, morning sickness has many causes, including hormone fluctuations, low blood pressure, low sugar levels, food allergies, poor diet, and stress.

Edema (fluid retention and bloating) is extremely common during pregnancy. Water seeps from the blood vessels into the surrounding tissue, causing puffiness. The ankles and calves are mostly affected.

Constipation often occurs as pregnancy develops. Pressure increases on the lower bowel, impeding circulation.

Heartburn (pain in the center of the chest) may also be caused by increased pressure within the body.

Stretch marks sometimes appear as the body swells. They can be minimized by rubbing aloe vera gel or olive oil into the skin to maintain its elasticity.

Childbirth can be helped by drinking raspberry leaf tea, a traditional remedy that prepares the uterine muscles for labor and giving birth.

Herbs During Pregnancy

- For the first 3 months avoid all herbal remedies, including essential oils, unless professionally prescribed.
- The following herbs are particularly dangerous and should on no account be taken during pregnancy: blue cohosh (*Caulophyllum thalictroides*, p. 185), goldenseal (*Hydrastis canadensis*, p. 105), juniper (*Juniperus communis*, p. 224), pennyroyal (*Mentha pulegium*, p. 235), yarrow (*Achillea millefolium*, p. 56), and therapeutic doses of sage (*Salvia officinalis*, p. 131).

Morning Sickness & Nausea

The following remedies are an exception and can be taken during the first 3 months of pregnancy.

Herb German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77)

Remedy Make an infusion in a covered container. Sip small quantities during the day. Do not drink more than 3 cups (750 ml) a day.

Herb Ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155)

Remedy Make an infusion with ½–1 tsp of grated fresh ginger per ¾ cup (150 ml) of water. Sip small amounts frequently throughout the day, rather than drinking ¾ cup (150 ml) at a time. Take a maximum of 1½ cups (450 ml) a day.

Herb Fennel (*Foeniculum vulgare*, p. 212)

Remedy Make an infusion with ½ tsp of seeds per ¾ cup (150 ml) of water and then drink up to 1½ cups (450 ml) a day.

Edema

Herb Cornsilk (*Zea mays*, p. 154)

Remedy Make an infusion and drink up to 3 cups (750 ml) a day.

Constipation

Herbs Psyllium (*Plantago* spp., p. 123), flaxseed (*Linum usitatissimum*, p. 109)

Remedy Take 1–2 tsp of either of the seeds with a large glass of water each day or soak them in cold water overnight before taking.

Note Eat more dried fruit, especially figs.

Heartburn

Herb Meadowsweet (*Filipendula ulmaria*, p. 98)

Remedy Make an infusion and drink ¾–1¼ cup (150–300 ml) a day.

Headache & Nervous Tension

Herb Linden (*Tilia* spp., p. 277)

Remedy Make an infusion and drink 1½–2½ cups (450–600 ml) a day.

Preparing for Childbirth

Herb Raspberry (*Rubus idaeus*, p. 264)

Remedy Make an infusion using 1 tsp of the chopped fresh or dried leaf per ¾ cup (150 ml) of water. Brew for 5–6 minutes and drink ¾–1 cup (150–300 ml) a day during the last 10 weeks of pregnancy.

Cautions Do not leave the infusion to brew for more than 5–6 minutes. Do not take until the last 10 weeks of pregnancy.

Stretch Marks

Herbs Aloe vera (*Aloe vera*, p. 60), olive (*Olea europaea*, p. 241)

Remedy Rub aloe vera gel over the affected areas or massage olive oil firmly into the skin 1–2 times a day.

Poor Sleep

See *Insomnia* (the German chamomile, linden, lavender, and passionflower remedy under *General Remedies*), p. 309.

Anemia & High Blood Pressure

See *Circulatory Problems*, p. 301.

Hemorrhoids

See *Varicose Veins & Hemorrhoids*, p. 302 and *Constipation & Diarrhea*, p. 307.

Backache

See *Back Pain*, p. 313.

Varicose Veins

See *Varicose Veins & Hemorrhoids*, p. 302.

Vaginal Yeast Infections

See *Fungal Infections*, p. 314.

Bladder & Kidney Infections

See *Edema*, left.

Healing After Childbirth

See *Cleansing Wounds & Healing Wounds*, p. 304.